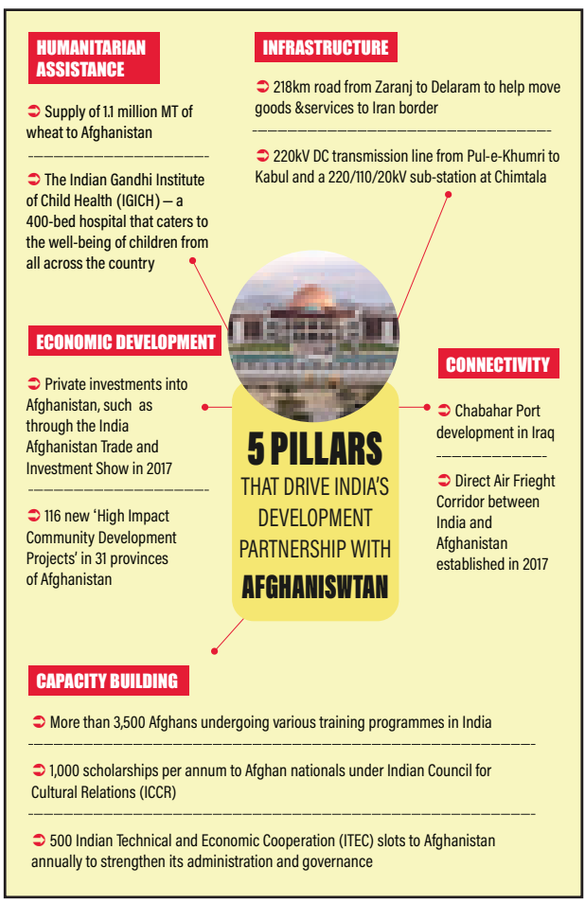
India has sought to establish its presence in Afghanistan from the early days of its independence in 1947.In 1950, Afghanistan and India signed a "Friendship Treaty."

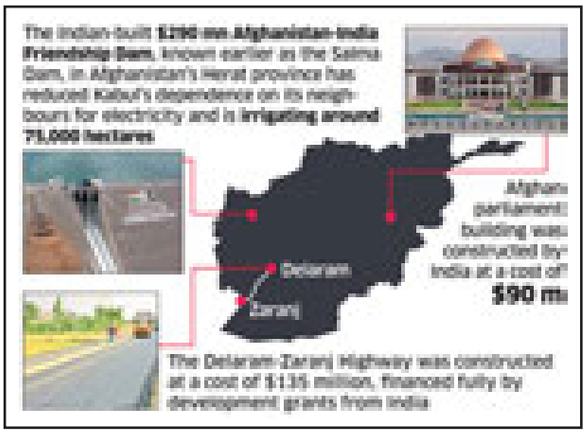
India had robust ties with Afghanistan during King Zahir Shah's regime. Prior to the Soviet invasion in 1979, India had formalized agreements and protocols with various Pro-Soviet regimes in Kabul. While India's role in Afghanistan was constrained during the Anti-Soviet jihad, between 1979 and 1989, India expanded its development activities in Afghanistan, focusing upon industrial, irrigation, and hydroelectric projects.



King Zahir Shah

After the Taliban consolidated their hold on Afghanistan in the mid-1990s, India





struggled to maintain its presence and to support anti-Taliban forces. However, Indian objectives in Afghanistan remained modest given the constrained environment. India aimed to undermine the ability of the Taliban to consolidate its power in Afghanistan, principally by supporting the Northern Alliance in tandem with other regional actors. Working with Iran, Russia, and Tajikistan, India provided important resources to the Northern Alliance, the only meaningful challenge to the Taliban in Afghanistan. Since 2001, India has relied upon development projects and other forms of humanitarian assistance. Expanding India's presence in Afghanistan through increased Indian training of Afghan civilian and military personnel, development projects, and expanded economic ties. India and Pakistan competition in Afghanistan is seen as a new "Great Game".



In 2005, India proposed Afghanistan's membership in SAARC and in April 3, 2007 it joined.

India-Afghanistan: Strategic interests

Afghan is India's natural ally. India is interested in retaining Afghanistan as a friendly state from which it has the capacity

12th_Political Science_Unit_10.indd 209 1/30/2020 4:13:31 PM